Jewish Holidays & Scheduling

PRACTICAL REFERENCE FOR PROFESSORS, EMPLOYERS & PROGRAM HOSTS

Some Jewish holidays involve restrictions on ordinary work, travel, writing, and the use of electronic devices. As a result, an observant student or employee may be unable to attend exams, shifts, scheduled meetings, or online activities during particular periods.

Jewish calendar dates start at sunset, and the exact beginning and end depend on the year and location. Practices vary among individuals and communities. This guide explains common Orthodox observance patterns and should not replace a conversation with the person requesting accommodation.

Common scheduling considerations

Observance	Typical timing	Potential impact
Shabbos	Every week, Friday sunset through Saturday nightfall	Observant Jews refrain from many forms of work, travel, and electronic communication.
Rosh Hashanah	Typically two festival days	Major festival observance; attendance, exams, work, travel, and electronics may be affected.
Yom Kippur	One day, beginning the preceding evening	Fast day and major festival; religious services and work restrictions affect availability.
Sukkos / Shemini Atzeres / Simchas Torah	Festival days around the Sukkos period	Full festival restrictions on specified days; intervening Chol Hamoed days differ.
Pesach (Passover)	First and final festival days within an eight-day diaspora observance	Full festival restrictions on specified days; intermediate days have different practices.
Shavuos	Typically two diaspora festival days	Major festival observance with restrictions similar to other festival days.

IMPORTANT DISTINCTION

Chanukah and Purim are also important Jewish observances, but they generally do not have the same festival-day work restrictions. Individual participation needs can still arise.

Helpful ways to respond

- Ask which exact dates and times are affected, rather than assuming every Jewish person observes identically.
- Consider alternative exam dates, assignment deadlines, meetings, or shifts when feasible and consistent with applicable policies.
- Avoid assuming that remote attendance solves a conflict: online participation may also be restricted.
- Confirm holiday dates for the relevant year and location using a reliable Jewish calendar.

Frequently asked questions

Why might an absence begin the evening before the calendar date? The Jewish day begins at sunset; some observances start before the date shown on a standard daytime calendar.

Can a student or employee participate remotely instead? Not always. Some observant Jews do not use electronic devices or travel during Shabbos and major festivals, so a virtual meeting can still conflict with observance.

Why are some festivals observed for two days? In many Orthodox diaspora communities, certain festivals are observed for an additional day; observance practices can differ by community and circumstance.

A useful accommodation conversation

Ask about the person’s actual schedule, the activity that conflicts, and the best way to address it under applicable school or workplace policies. An alternative date or adjusted requirement is often more useful than a generic absence note. Do not request unnecessary details about private religious practices.

Educational summary, not a substitute for institutional policy, professional religious guidance, or legal advice. Designed for general awareness; obtain specialist review before wider publication.